

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Andy Lapsa, Founder & CEO, Stoke Space **Released September 29, 2025**

Jessica: Carolynn, I'm so excited because today, we are at the Y Combinator Founder Mode Retreat.
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Carolynn: Mhmm.
[\(00:00:06\)](#)

Jessica: And we are sitting down with Andy Lapsa, the founder and CEO of Stoke Space. Welcome. Welcome, Andy. Thank you, Andy. I'd like you to tell our listeners a little bit about Stoke.
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Very exciting company.

Andy: We are a vertically integrated launch service provider. We're building fully rapidly reusable rockets that go to space. They can move around in space and then come back to ground. And the idea is to make space in the space economy, and specifically transportation mobility to, through, and from space just a natural extension of other mobility solutions around the world.
[\(00:00:20\)](#)

Carolynn: For example, you take satellites up to space.
[\(00:00:39\)](#)

Andy: Yeah. That's I mean, that's the main, application today, but I think there's some really exciting if you have mobility solved, if you can access space the same way we use access, you know, other modes of transportation. You go to the UPS store, you drop off a box, you say, I want it there in three days, and it gets there. Right? What if space is one of those options.
[\(00:00:42\)](#)

So there are a lot of applications you can build on top of that provided that the availability is there and the price point is there.

Jessica: And you went through YC in winter twenty one, but what when did you start the company, and what was your background?
[\(00:01:10\)](#)

Andy: Yeah. So, officially, we started at the end of twenty nineteen, but we started effectively on a thesis, but we didn't really have a way respond to the thesis from a technical or a plan perspective. So that first year was a lot of, I would say I mean, you could call it my cofounder and I doing diligence on this thesis for ourselves
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Jessica: Okay.
[\(00:01:39\)](#)

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Andy: [\(00:01:40\)](#) Seeing if we could come up with a technical solution for fully rapidly reusable rockets that we believed in. And so that was a lot of very heads down effort. And then as we gained, you know, conviction ourselves, we said, okay. Let's go and try to, you know, do this thing for real. And that's when we did YC in, winter twenty one batch, and closed our seed round and, you know, really started to ramp from there.

Carolynn: [\(00:02:07\)](#) And just to be a little more detailed, it's the reusable part means that it's cost effective. Like, the idea here is that you can save all this money because you keep reusing the parts, which right now, everything just explodes or something.

Andy: [\(00:02:22\)](#) Right now, well, let's say this. Before SpaceX, every rocket that went to space, the entire thing gets thrown away after every flight. So you can imagine air transportation being not very economical and not very accessible. Right. If you threw away the airplane after every flight. And that's what space was.

Yeah. Right? SpaceX came along and it's you know, we've now started to take it for granted, but, really, it was only ten years ago, when they did the first landing of their booster stage. Rockets are typically two stages to orbit. First stage, like, punches you out of the atmosphere, and the second stage takes you the rest of the way to space.

And so they started reusing the first stage, which is transformational for the industry, but they still throw away the second stage on every single flight. And so that means a couple things. First of all, it costs money, obviously, to build this. Right. And the other big thing is it is you know, we're still in this production rate limited paradigm where you can only fly as many times as you can produce, in their case, second stages, which is a stage.

It's a second stage engine. It's the certification and test preflight certification test campaigns that go into all of the components that go into that stage, etcetera, etcetera. Right? So that's their flight rate limiter today, and it's also their cost driver.

Carolynn: [\(00:03:40\)](#) What's the expensive part? Is it the parts, or is it all of it?

Andy: [\(00:03:44\)](#) Yeah. So there are two big cost drivers to launch. One is the vehicle cost. Interestingly, though, the vehicle cost of a rocket, is less than the cost of a seven thirty seven, comfortably less than a seven thirty seven. Right?

But it's still tens of millions of dollars. Sure. Okay? So that's a cost driver, especially if you're throwing it away every time. Yeah.

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The other big cost driver in launch is the infrastructure that you need. So it is the factory. It's the test facilities for engines and for other high energy, you know, explosives and other things that that we deal with every day. And then it's the launch infrastructure, the launch complex, that it takes to actually go and execute. Those are the two big cost drivers.

And what reusability does is again, go back to the aircraft analogy. Right? Makes absolutely no sense to throw away a \$120,000,000.07 37 on every flight. You're not gonna access that many customers that way. You're not gonna have great availability, and that's where we're at with space.

So reusability amortizes the cost of that \$100,000,000 asset, whatever it is. Right? It amortizes the cost. So the more you can launch that item, the more you like, the amortized cost goes down. So that's number one.

And then, the infrastructure costs and the fixed costs, which includes the cost of labor as the other big driver, and to get those costs down like, you need that infrastructure just to go do this activity. Yeah. But the way you can effectively amortize those costs is by flying at a higher frequency. So before SpaceX started reusing, I think this is still true. There is no company so when we're in this world where we're throwing away rockets every time, there's no company that flew more than 16 times per year.

Jessica:
[\(00:05:34\)](#)

Okay.

Andy:
[\(00:05:36\)](#)

And it's, you know, it's like a really small number, but that's because we were completely production rate limited.

Jessica:
[\(00:05:41\)](#)

Yeah.

Andy:
[\(00:05:42\)](#)

And SpaceX actually fits into that number also. Before they started reusing the first stage, they didn't fly more than 16 times a year. I'm pretty sure that's a number. Once they started reusing the first stage, now they get to like, the first stage is bigger. It's more expensive.

It is the right first stage to start reusing. But they're able to basically shift their factory from producing first stages into full on, like, crank out second stages. Yeah. And that's what enabled them to scale from 16 flights a year up to now in the neighborhood of 150.

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Carolynn: Really? I didn't think you were gonna say that big of a number.
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Andy: It's a big number for space.
[\(00:06:18\)](#)

Carolynn: Number for space.
[\(00:06:20\)](#)

Andy: But it's a small amount of pittance for any other mode of transportation. Right?
[\(00:06:21\)](#)

Carolynn: That's
[\(00:06:25\)](#)

Andy: True. And so, you know, if they wanna do 300, they have to double their factory and double their test facilities and whatnot. Right?
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Jessica: So What and are they
[\(00:06:32\)](#)

Carolynn: Are they also working on the second stage?
[\(00:06:33\)](#)

Andy: They're doing a whole new vehicle called Starship, and that is intended to be fully reasonable.
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Jessica: Okay.
[\(00:06:41\)](#)

Andy: But they're not there yet.
[\(00:06:41\)](#)

Jessica: Right. So is this your first I mean, let's first of all mention this is the epitome of hard tech. And is this your first startup?
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Andy: It's my first startup.
[\(00:06:52\)](#)

Jessica: You found it.
[\(00:06:53\)](#)

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Andy:
[\(00:06:54\)](#)

I've been in the industry. You know?

Jessica:
[\(00:06:56\)](#)

Okay. Tell us about how you have evolved. How big is your company? I wanna hear how you've evolved as a manager, and what does Founder Mode mean to you?

Andy:
[\(00:07:06\)](#)

Sure. So, yeah, I was in the industry for a while, we started, as myself and my cofounder. And today, we're, you know, a little bit north of 260 people. So we've been very methodically scaling in terms of, headcount. Obviously, when you start, there's a huge number of variables.

Funding is one of them. Technical progress is one of them. The ability to attract, recruit, and retain talent is one of them.

Carolynn:
[\(00:07:34\)](#)

And you're recruiting rocket scientists, I would just note. Right?

Andy:
[\(00:07:37\)](#)

Yeah. Mean, it's a lot of specialized things, and then there's other things where there's transferable skill sets. So we'll bring people in from outside the industry and train them up and things like that.

Carolynn:
[\(00:07:45\)](#)

But Yeah.

Andy:
[\(00:07:48\)](#)

So, anyway, there's a lot of variables, and, it's it's, I would say for me, it's been very useful to have prior experience to sort of form how I think about, building and scaling a company from scratch given the opportunity to do whatever you want. Right? So however you think it should have been, we have the opportunity to go and try to do that. So that's been fun. Maybe that's part one of your question and part numb part two of the question is

Jessica:
[\(00:08:18\)](#)

I had a lot of questions.

Carolynn:
[\(00:08:20\)](#)

Confusion to my question. Yeah.

Andy:
[\(00:08:23\)](#)

The Founder Mode question is a great one. Founder Mode obviously got a lot of attention in the last, what, year or six months

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Jessica: Or whatever this ago.
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Andy: Was it really a year ago?
[\(00:08:31\)](#)

Jessica: Gave his, like, mind blowing talk at a YC.
[\(00:08:32\)](#)

Andy: Yeah. It was at this one month.
[\(00:08:36\)](#)

Jessica: It was this conference. Yeah. And while Paul wrote the essay, and it's sort of he's defined it as, you know, doing things as a founder, CEO that a hired CEO wouldn't necessarily be able to do. We don't know what it's like in practice. Yeah.

So we were collect Carolyn and I are collecting examples to learn more

Andy: About it. I think founder mode is exactly what you said where, a founder is just acutely aware that survival is on the line, and that survival is very personal, and it's real, and it's always this threat. Right? It's like you are always on edge about the threat to survive. Mhmm.

And that just engenders a different level of urgency required.

Jessica: Yeah.
[\(00:09:26\)](#)

Andy: So Founder Mode, I think, is, you know, it is the it is how that urgency manifests in day to day activity or, you know, what it takes to get something done. And, you know, for us, we have, I think, terrible market timing in terms of, the fundraising markets. Right? When we started, we were winter twenty one. COVID had just hit.

You know? Nobody's investing in anything except trying to, like, understand what the world meant at that point and keep their portfolios alive. Nobody wanted to work on or, like, invest in this kind of crazy rocket company. Right? So that took and by the way, I'm first time founder and didn't really have any network for fundraising.

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So, it was both trying to figure that out and grow the network and navigate that at a time when, you know, it certainly wasn't the hot topic on Silicon Valley. And then, you know, so we did that. We muscled through the seed. YC certainly was a huge help for that. And then, and then '21 was an okay market.

But then, you know, in the 2324 time frame, it was a really difficult market, especially for hardware growth companies and especially for companies like ours that were kind of in this, let's call it a tween age stage where we are in the market for proper growth capital, but we're still premarket in terms of revenue generation. Right?

Carolynn:
[\(00:10:54\)](#)

Right. Right.

Andy:
[\(00:10:55\)](#)

So this is the classic hardware valley of death.

Carolynn:
[\(00:10:58\)](#)

Right.

Andy:
[\(00:10:58\)](#)

Right? And so we had to figure out how to navigate that in a difficult market as well. For us, the founder mode really started with, you know, how we have this idea. We have taken our time and found conviction in ourselves that that we have a good idea that we think holds water, which, by the way, has only been reinforced over the last, you know, four years. So we've we still feel really excited about it.

But, like, what do we do next? And, and so we did a number of things, but, I think the beginning of Founder Mode was we wanna differentiate ourselves. We didn't want to raise on, you know, what we would call a PowerPoint rocket or, you know, flashy marketing. We wanted to differentiate ourselves and say, hey. We are no joke, hardware driven people, and we will deliver on what we say.

And so we bought a shipping container. We had it dropped off in my cofounder's yard. We started building a little rocket test stand in his yard, and that was kind of a wild time.

Carolynn:
[\(00:12:01\)](#)

I bet.

Andy:
[\(00:12:03\)](#)

But, yeah, I think it's all about the urgency you feel around survival. But I would say, you know, now that we've scaled a little bit

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Jessica:
[\(00:12:11\)](#)

Mhmm.

Andy:
[\(00:12:11\)](#)

It's it's my, my sentiment around founder mode is maybe evolved. Mhmm. That is what founder mode is. It's you will do whatever it takes to get the job done. Whatever's in front of you, it has to get done.

There's nobody else to do it. You just have to do whatever it's gonna take. Whatever

Carolynn:
[\(00:12:30\)](#)

That stuff.

Andy:
[\(00:12:31\)](#)

Right? Even crazy stuff. Now that we scaled a little bit, I have founder mode invokes for me in two different ways. The first way is if I feel like I have to go into founder mode, which is go in there and do something myself, whatever it's gonna take. To me, I view that as a failure of the like, I have failed to put the organization in a place to succeed itself.

Right? The organization, like, everybody in the company should feel Founder Mode.

Jessica:
[\(00:13:04\)](#)

Okay.

Andy:
[\(00:13:05\)](#)

And they should feel the ownership and the urgency to get their thing done. And if I feel like I need to go do something, that implicitly means it's not getting done. So I have failed to create the organization Oh, okay. To have its own founder mode through the org.

Carolynn:
[\(00:13:20\)](#)

How can you feel like that happens?

Andy:
[\(00:13:22\)](#)

You know, we are a still a early and growing company. So, I still feel like that happens a lot. Right? Like, I would say that we have unfilled holes in our company

Jessica:
[\(00:13:34\)](#)

Yeah.

Andy:
[\(00:13:35\)](#)

As any company that's scaling will. And who's gonna fill those? Right? And so it's always a competition between, keeping people focused or asking them to go fill a hole or whatever. Right?

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So it does happen a lot. Yeah. But that means that the organization is not yet

Carolynn: But that doesn't that doesn't make you really feel like a failure. It just reminds you of, like, what you have to do to get to this place you wanna go. Because it would be awful to feel like a

Andy: Failure all the time. Right? Or if something's not functioning Yeah. The way that it should be, then, you know, the organization is not working.

Jessica: Yeah. Yeah.

Andy: Right? So it's, it's kind of constant maintenance. Yeah. That's one thing. The other place you see it all the time is, let's say there's an opportunity that is adjacent or not exactly what you were working on and set up the company to do.

Mhmm. But it would be a huge loss if you don't go and leverage that or capture that opportunity. Yeah. We're not set up to do this opportunity, but it's something that we wanna do. Yeah.

That requires Founder Mode. Right? Mhmm. Because now you have to go and scramble, and you're flexing, you're doing whatever it takes to do this thing that the company and the organization wasn't set up to do. Right.

Right? And that's always like, the decision to go after or not go after is an important one because as a early in scaling company, you have to stay focused and you have to continue to execute on your core Right.

Jessica: And is that a distraction?

Andy: And is it gonna be a distraction? Exactly. And so that's a judgment call you have to make. But once you make the decision, you gotta go all in. Yeah.

Jessica: Yeah. Thank you

Andy: So much.

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Jessica: Thank you, Andy. And hope to see you again on the show someday. Alright. And best of
[\(00:15:07\)](#) luck to Stoke.

Andy: Thank you.
[\(00:15:12\)](#)